

Figure 5. View of the middle ghats in Varanasi, May 2019

All boatmen in Varanasi belong to a single caste community, the Mallahs (or Nishads). As a group, they've been vital to the city's commerce, pilgrimage and tourist economy for centuries. They've managed to corner the profession with claims of traditional and hereditary rights, scriptural sanction and lobbying like a labour union. Consequently, while not all Mallahs are boatmen, all boatmen are Mallahs.

The Mallahs were deemed a 'criminal tribe' by the British. This assessment had two sources. First, as the East India Company began controlling the commerce on the river routes and taxing the flow of goods on them, friction with the locals led to thefts and attacks on Company boats. This was seen to be led, or at least enabled, by the Mallahs. Second, many Mallah subcastes, among them 'Bind, Chain, Dhimar, Kahar, Kevat, Muriari, Sorahiya, and Tiyar', had dietary habits and social customs that scandalized the British. They reportedly ate rats, tortoises, crocodiles and